Kritagya Dhanda

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Office Contact Information

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Chris Muris
Placement Officer
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McMaster University
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Graduate Studies

McMaster University 2021–present
PhD in Economics
Advisor: Professor Adam Lavecchia
Committee Members: Professor Angela Zheng, Professor Arthur Sweetman, Professor Jevan Cherniwchan, Professor Michel Grignon
Expected completion: Aug 2027

References

Professor Adam Lavecchia
Department of Economics
McMaster University
lavecchia@mcmaster.ca

Professor Angela Zhang
Department of Economics
McMaster University
zhenga17@mcmaster.ca

Professor Arthur Sweetman
Department of Economics
McMaster University
sweetman@mcmaster.ca

Professor Jevan Cherniwchan
Department of Economics
McMaster University
cherniwj@mcmaster.ca

Fields

Labour Economics, Health Economics, Applied Microeconomics

Prior Education

University of Windsor 2019–2021
Master of Arts in Economics

Anant National University 2018–2019
Post Graduate Diploma in Built Environment

Ambedkar University Delhi 2013–2016
Honours Bachelor of Arts in Economics

Experience

Analyst 2016–2017
Quality Council of India

Research Intern June–July 2014
Pratham Education Foundation

Last updated: October 2026

Personal

Indian Citizen Canadian Permanent Resident

Research

Job Market Paper

Enrollment, Tuition Subsidies and Welfare: Evidence from Ontario's Tuition Grant

This paper estimates the effect of tuition subsidies on post-secondary enrollment, identifies the channels through which subsidies operate, and evaluates their welfare implications. I exploit the introduction of Ontario's 30% Tuition Grant (OTG) in 2012, which provides up to $1,680 ($780) annually to income-eligible students enrolled in university (college), using a triple-difference design that leverages variation in parental income, province of residence, and program rollout. Linked administrative tax and post-secondary records for 1.5-generation immigrant children permit direct observation of parental resources and enrollment decisions. Eligibility for the grant increased enrollment by 3 percentage points. The response is concentrated among students whose parents hold little to no capital income, consistent with binding liquidity constraints. I embed the estimated enrollment elasticity in a two-period sufficient-statistics framework to decompose the welfare gain into a liquidity benefit and a fiscal externality. I find that an additional dollar of grant spending raises social welfare by $1.32, with the fiscal externality from the expanded tax base as the dominant channel.

Working Papers

(i) Physiological Constraints and Behavioral Adaptation: How high stakes professionals respond to fasting during Ramadan *with Stephen Strobel and Mohammed Basit Gilani*

Physiological constraints are often assumed to reduce worker productivity, but workers may instead adapt by changing effort across tasks or over time. We study this question in the Indian Premier League, a high-stakes professional cricket setting with ball-by-ball measures of output. We examine how Muslim batters respond to Ramadan fasting, a predictable physiological shock that potentially affects production. We compare Muslim and non-Muslim players using a difference-in-regression-discontinuities design that uses rule changes over the course of IPL games during and outside the Ramadan period. Muslim players during Ramadan smooth performance over match phases: early high-intensity production is muted, while later production is preserved or increases. Complementary difference-in-differences estimators suggest similar within player results and that teams respond modestly by substituting fasting players at higher rates. The results suggest that when production is divisible and workers can substitute effort across tasks, predictable physiological constraints can alter the composition of output more than its level.

(ii) Evaluation of Family Planning Policy in India Using Synthetic Control Methods

Publicly funded family planning services have a considerable influence on the fertility decisions of women and, consequently maternal and child health. In November, 2016 an expansive family planning program was launched in 145 districts in seven provinces of India that had previously shown high fertility rates. The program featured (i) increase access to a range of contraceptives, (ii) monetary incentives for beneficiaries who adopt family planning methods, and (iii) information dissemination using mobile vans covering all blocks of a district. This paper documents the effects of this family planning program on a broad set of maternal and child outcomes. I use the generalized synthetic control method to estimate the average treatment effect on the treated districts utilizing administrative data from Health Management Information System of India aggregated to

the district level for periods 2009-19. The estimates suggest that the program increased deliveries by 4.6, institutional deliveries of infants by 3.9 and infants weighed at birth by 3.2 per one thousand women of reproductive age. New cases of pregnant women with hypertension decreased by 2 per one thousand women of reproductive age. Heterogeneous treatment effects suggest that the program decreased the fraction of infants born with low-birth-weight in districts with high initial economic activity and increased it in districts with low initial economic activity.

Pre-PhD Publications

- Su, L., and Dhanda, K. (2021) "Financial Capability Formation and the variables that effect it with respect to Canadian consumers." *International Journal of Applied Research in Management and Economics*, Volume 4(3), pp. 19–42.

Teaching

McMaster University
Instructor — Winter 2026
Intermediate Microeconomics – I (2Z03)

Teaching Assistant
Econometrics – I (3EE3), Applied Econometrics (3E03), Labour Economics (3D03), Intermediate Microeconomics – II (3ZZ3), Intermediate Macroeconomics – I (2H03)

Academic Service

Faculty of Social Sciences, McMaster University
- Graduate Council Member — 2025–2026
- Graduate Curriculum and Policy Committee Member — 2026–2027

Honors, Scholarships, Fellowships, and Grants

- 2025: Research Scholarship, McMaster University, $6,000
- 2021: Graduate Scholarship, McMaster University, $3,000
- 2018: Young Visionary Scholarship, Anant National University, $19,000

Presentations

- 2026:
  - 119th Annual Conference on Taxation, *Pennsylvania* (forthcoming),
  - 21st Annual Conference on Economic Growth and Development, *Delhi* (forthcoming)
  - Alberta Center for Labour Market Research Conference: Immigration and the Future of Labour, *Edmonton* (*Video Link*),
  - Canadian Economic Association, *Vancouver*,
  - Summer Workshop in Economic Analysis and Theory, *Toronto*,
- 2025
  - Canadian Economic Association, *Montréal*,
  - 119th India Management Research Conference (IMRC), *Ahmedabad*,
- 2020:

– International Conference on Advanced Research in Business, Management and Economics (ICABME), *Stockholm (virtual)*